

Making blog posts harvestable by Zotero and preserving case in citation fields

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Image: An image of the Zotero logo. (Zotero)

This is a quick “how-to” post because I learned something about Zotero. I want the posts on this site to be easily citeable. The name of the site that I would like in citations is “eve.gd: Martin Paul Eve”. But here’s the problem: when you put that as a Blog Title (or Website Title) and then go to cite it in a document, the CSL reformats it to the ugly “Eve.Gd: Martin Paul Eve”. Anyway, I found how to fix this! You simply encode it thus:

```
<span class="nocase">eve.gd</span>: Martin Paul Eve
```

Then the CSL will preserve your original case. `<span class="nocase">bell hooks</span>` might have found this useful, as might `<span class="nocase">andré carrington</span>` .

Mind you, those two are jokes only, as Zotero automatically preserves the casing of author names.

The next challenge that I faced was: how do you get an item into Zotero with the “Blog Post” type when you are running a static-site generator? Well, obviously, you have to embed meta tags, but which ones?

The key: force the item type with `zotero:itemType`

Genre/OpenGraph hints alone are unreliable — `prism.genre=blogentry` is *supposed* to map to Blog Post, but in practice Zotero kept importing posts as **Web Page** (the OpenGraph default won). The dependable fix is Zotero’s own RDFa override, `zotero:itemType`, which is read **first** in the translator’s type precedence (`t.zotero || t.bib || t.prism || ... || t.og || ...` in `RDF.js`) and beats everything else.

Two parts are required, because `zotero` is **not** a built-in prefix in the translator (only the short `z` is), so it must be declared:

1. Declare the prefix on the `<html>` element (the translator’s `getPrefixes` reads the `prefix` attribute of `<html>` and `<head>`):

```
<html lang="en" prefix="og: http://ogp.me/ns# article: http://ogp.me/ns/article#  
zotero: http://www.zotero.org/namespaces/export#">
```

2. Emit the override (note `property=`, not `name=`):

```
<meta property="zotero:itemType" content="blogPost">
```

The `prefix` value is RDFa syntax: `prefix: uri` pairs separated by spaces (a space **after** each colon is required by the parser’s `(\w+):\s+(\S+)` regex).

Required tags

Tag	Value	Effect
<code><html prefix="...zotero: http://www.zotero.org/namespaces/export#"></code>	(declaration)	Registers the <code>zotero</code> prefix so the next tag is understood.
<code>zotero:itemType</code> (property)	<code>blogPost</code>	Forces item type → Blog Post. Highest-priority signal.
<code>prism.publicationName</code>	<code>eve.gd: Martin Paul Eve</code>	Blog Title. Read before <code>og:site_name</code> . The <code></code> is CSL markup so styles don't title-case <code>eve.gd</code> into <code>Eve.Gd</code> .
<code>og:title</code>	post title	Title. Use OpenGraph/ <code>dc.title</code> , not <code>citation_title</code> (see below).
<code>citation_author</code>	<code>Eve, Martin Paul</code>	Author (<code>Last, First</code> ; repeat for multiple).
<code>citation_publication_date</code>	<code>2022/07/26</code>	Date (<code>YYYY/MM/DD</code>).
<code>citation_doi</code>	<code>10.59348/kv1zh-wn208</code>	DOI (bare, not a URL).
<code>citation_public_url</code>	<code>https://eve.gd/2022/07/26/.../</code>	URL (absolute).
<code>citation_language</code>	<code>en</code>	Language.

Secondary / belt-and-braces

Tag	Purpose
<code>prism.genre = blogentry</code>	Secondary type hint (kept in case <code>zotero:itemType</code> is ever ignored).

Tag	Purpose
<code>dc.title</code> / <code>dc.creator</code> / <code>dc.date</code> / <code>dc.language</code>	Dublin Core fallbacks for other reference tools.

Tags to AVOID for a blog post

Tag	Problem
<code>citation_journal_title</code>	Forces the <code>journalArticle</code> type.
<code>citation_title</code>	Makes the translator guess <code>journalArticle</code> . Supply the title via <code>og:title</code> / <code>dc.title</code> instead.

Notes

- `og:site_name` stays clean (`eve.gd: Martin Paul Eve` , no markup) because it also drives social-card previews; the case-protected title rides in `prism.publicationName` , which Zotero reads first.
- `<span class="nocase">...</span>` is one of Zotero's allowed rich-text tags, so it survives import; Zotero's item pane may show the raw markup in the field even though citations render correctly.
- After changing these tags, **Reset Translators** in Zotero (Preferences → Advanced) and test on the deployed page, since the connector caches translators.

So this should now work!

I must also add my thanks to Tom Elliott, whose [own blog post on this subject](#) gave me the information I needed to get the Blog Post type working. It is a shame that he stopped posting on his blog in 2020. I hope all is OK with him, but there are lots of interesting digital humanities posts on his site, on eclectic topics.